



Home › Living in Korea › Visa Guide


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Korea Visa Guide — Types, Requirements & How to Apply

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Whether you're visiting for two weeks or planning to live and work in Korea long-term, understanding Korean visas is essential. This guide breaks down all the main visa types, who qualifies, and how to apply.

Important: Visa rules change frequently. Always verify current requirements with the official **Korean Immigration Service (HiKorea)** or your nearest Korean embassy before applying.

Visa-Free Entry

Citizens of many countries can enter Korea without a visa for short stays. Most English-speaking countries (USA, UK, Canada, Australia, New Zealand, Ireland) are eligible for **90-day visa-free stays** as tourists.

Check your country

Korea offers visa-free access to citizens of 100+ countries. Check the full list on the Korean Ministry of Foreign Affairs website. The visa-free period varies from 30 to 90 days depending on nationality.

Common Visa Types

Visa	Who It's For	Duration
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C-3 (Tourist)	Short-term visitors, tourism, family visits	Up to 90 days
D-2 (Student)	University or language school students	Duration of study
D-10 (Job Seeker)	Graduates seeking employment in Korea	Up to 1 year
E-2 (English Teacher)	Native English speakers teaching at schools	1 year (renewable)
E-7 (Skilled Worker)	Professionals in specific fields	1–3 years
F-2 (Resident)	Long-term residents, spouses of Koreans	1–3 years
F-4 (Overseas Korean)	Ethnic Koreans with foreign citizenship	3 years
F-6 (Marriage Migrant)	Foreign spouses of Korean nationals	1 year (renewable)
Working Holiday	Youth (18–30) from eligible countries	1 year

Working Holiday Visa (H-1)

One of the most popular options for young foreigners. If you're between 18–30 (some countries up to 35) and a citizen of an eligible country, you can live and work in Korea for up to one year.

Eligible countries include: Australia, New Zealand, Canada, UK, Ireland, France, Germany, Japan, and many more (30+ countries total).

Requirements

- Valid passport with at least 6 months validity
- Proof of sufficient funds (typically ₩3,000,000 or equivalent)
- Return flight or proof of funds to purchase one
- No criminal record certificate
- Medical insurance

Tip: Working Holiday visas are issued on a quota basis. Apply early — some countries fill their quota within hours of the application window opening.

E-2 Visa — English Teacher

The E-2 visa allows native English speakers to teach English at public schools, private academies (hagwons), or universities in Korea.

Requirements

- Citizenship of an English-speaking country (USA, UK, Canada, Australia, New Zealand, Ireland, South Africa)
- Bachelor's degree (any field)
- Criminal background check (apostilled)
- Health check
- Signed employment contract with a Korean school

Most E-2 teachers are placed through programs like **EPIK** (government schools) or by applying directly to private hagwons. Salaries typically range from ₩2.0M to ₩3.2M per month, usually with free housing.

D-10 — Job Seeker Visa

Relatively new and increasingly popular. The D-10 allows you to stay in Korea for up to one year while actively job hunting. Ideal for recent graduates or career changers wanting to find work locally.

Basic Requirements

- Bachelor's degree or higher from a recognized university
- Proof of sufficient funds to support yourself
- Health insurance
- Evidence of job search activity (applications, interviews, etc.)

How to Apply

1. **Identify the right visa** for your situation and purpose of stay
2. **Gather all required documents** — start early, as some (like apostilled background checks) take weeks
3. **Apply at the nearest Korean embassy or consulate** in your home country

4. **Pay the visa fee** (varies by type and country)
5. **Register with immigration within 90 days** of arriving in Korea if staying long-term (get your ARC — Alien Registration Card)

HiKorea — Official Portal

For all official visa information, application tracking, and ARC registration, use the Korean government's immigration portal:

hikorea.go.kr

Alien Registration Card (ARC)

If you're staying in Korea for more than 90 days, you must register with your local immigration office and obtain an ARC. This card is essential for opening a bank account, getting a mobile plan, and accessing most services in Korea.

Apply at your nearest **Immigration Office (출입국관리사무소)** or book an appointment online through HiKorea. Bring your passport, visa, proof of address, and a recent photo.

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